Can Chisel keep track of a whole novel?

A stress test on Crime and Punishment, The Brothers Karamazov and War and Peace, and what we built because of it. Report to the project owner, 19 October 2026.

What you asked
Test Chisel's AI tools on long public-domain novels. Can it still pick up names, keep track of the story and check continuity? Or does it need some way to condense the book so the whole story stays in view? Plan it with Notes2Flow, run it with AgenticNodes, check it with a classifier such as Jev, document everything, and explain what did and did not work in plain terms.

The short version

- **Chisel never shows the AI more than the chapter you are working on plus your character notes.** We measured this on all three books. It sends roughly 1,600 to 13,500 chunks of text (a chunk is about three-quarters of a word) per request, and exactly the same amount whether the AI model can read 32 thousand chunks or a million. A bigger model does not help: earlier chapters are simply not in the request.
- **We built a "summary memory" and it works as a tool.** Each chapter gets a short summary, a list of facts (each backed by a quote from the chapter that code checks), who is in the scene and what is left open. You review every summary before it is kept. Summarising all of War and Peace (365 chapters) cost 17 US cents and about half an hour; Karamazov 6 cents; Crime and Punishment about 10 cents.
- **Our first version had real flaws, and the testing found them.** It threw away 37% of the facts it was given (they were true; our quote check was too strict) and the cheap AI model spent most of its effort "thinking" invisibly, which was slow and costly. Both are fixed: 4% thrown away, and thinking can be switched off.
- **Summaries did not help catch contradictions, and we now know why.** We hid six contradictions in Crime and Punishment (for example a character's age changed from 45 to 52, many chapters after it was stated). Today's notes alone found none; summaries or fact lists found at most one; a perfect hand-written fact list found four of six, but only when the model was allowed to think. A free check explains why: for five of the six hidden contradictions, the original fact (an age, a colour, a metal, a number of years, a floor) was never recorded in any summary, so no model could have found it from the summaries. Only the changed roubles were there, and only in the summary prose.
- **The tool that targets such details fell short at first, and the fix worked.** Chisel's existing "canon" tool proposes facts about each character. Our quote check threw away 98% of its output, and notes built from what survived caught nothing. After we changed it to give one quote per fact and to look for stable details first, it kept 95% of its facts, put five of the six contradicted facts into the right character's note, and a check on those notes caught two or three of six (none before). That is still below the hand-written notes (four of six), and it raised more false alarms. A one-sentence fix for

those false alarms was tested and made them worse, so it was not shipped. A stricter code-checked rule (each finding must quote the scene and the notes) cut them by 40% but also lowered catches; it is built and committed, not adopted.

- **The weakest link is also the checking.** The cheap models raised many false alarms (often 1 to 7 of 8 untouched chapters), gave different answers when we repeated an identical run (about 30% of results changed), and one model produced no usable answer at all in its default mode.
- **Two Chisel features behave badly at book scale regardless:** notes are cut to a handful once a project has 40 or more of them, and the "find aliases" tool returned nothing in every test.

What I recommend
1. Keep the summaries as an *overview memory*, described honestly. 2. Make the fixed canon tool (stable details, one verified quote per fact) the continuity memory, with the author reviewing what goes into the notes. 3. Decide whether to adopt the built two-quote check (false alarms down 40%, catches down 0.8 of 6); the simple wording fix did not work. 4. Fix the alias finder and the 40-note cliff. 5. Do not claim book-scale continuity checking until it is re-tested on a real manuscript with a stronger model. Details in section 9.

1. How the work was organised

You asked for a careful plan, built with your own tools, and a record of everything. This is what was done, so you can judge how far to trust the numbers later in this report.

Planning in Notes2Flow

I wrote the plan as plain notes (goal, what we believed, assumptions, three decisions with options, eleven steps, eight tests with pass marks, rules for helpers). Notes2Flow turned the notes into a map of claims, decisions and actions, with a word-for-word quote behind every box, and ran its logic review. **The first map was poor:** it showed none of the step-by-step dependencies I had written (0 of 11), because my sentences were too loose. I rewrote them as explicit "step N requires step M" lines and the second map contained all 11 (Figure 1). The review also caught a real gap: one test (the repeat-run test) was not tied to any step, which I fixed. Figure 2 is Notes2Flow's flowchart of the work order. Cost of all this: under one cent.

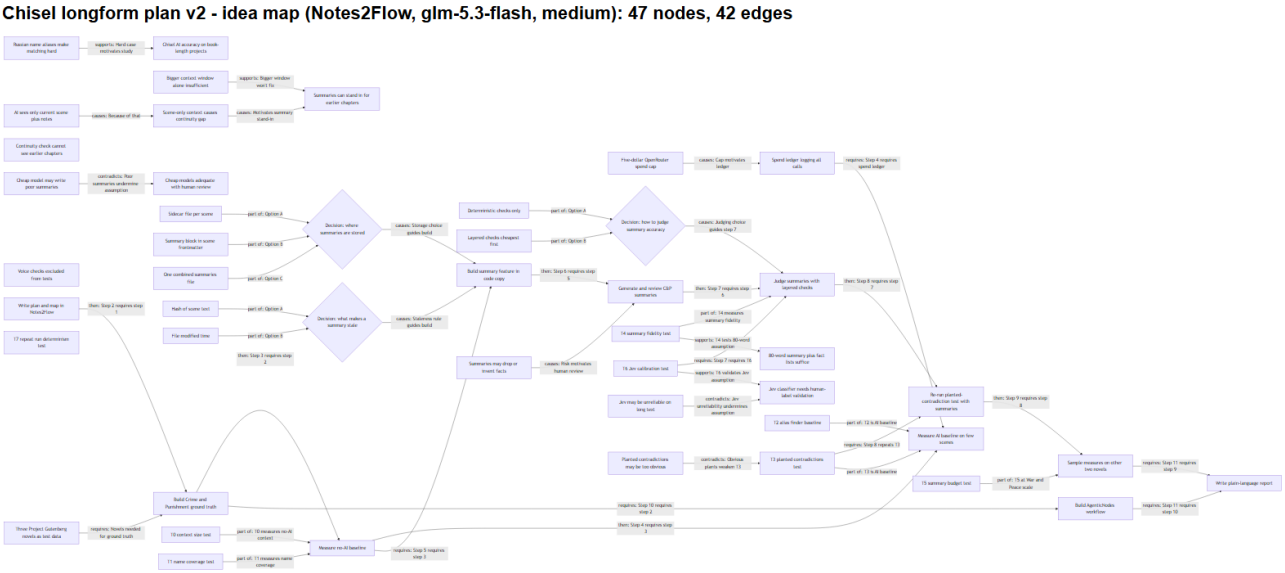


Figure 1. *The plan as Notes2Flow mapped it (second version, 47 boxes). Diamonds are decisions; every box carries a checked quote from the plan notes. All eleven stated step dependencies are present. Zoom in to read the labels.*

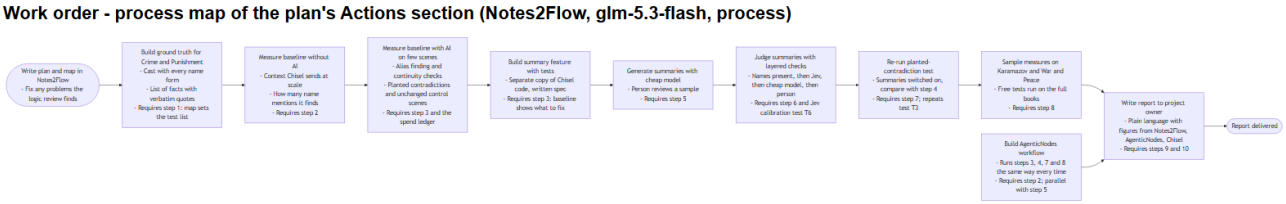


Figure 2. *The work order as a flowchart, also produced by Notes2Flow from the plan's action list. One arrow is missing (step 2 to step 10), a known extraction error; the idea map above has it.*

Helpers, run in herdr

To keep my own usage down I acted as project manager and used lighter helper agents, each started in its own herdr pane with a written brief. I read every report, re-checked a sample of their work myself, and kept a log (LOG.md) and a spend ledger (SPEND.md). The helpers and their model class:

Helper	Model class	Job
mapper	light (Haiku)	Notes2Flow maps of the plan and the work order
truth	mid (Sonnet)	Ground truth for Crime and Punishment: 25 characters with every name form, 40 verified facts with quotes, 10 candidate planted edits
casts	light (Haiku)	Character casts for Karamazov (25) and War and Peace (60)
baseline	mid (Sonnet)	No-AI measurements of what Chisel sends and which names it finds
builder (several rounds of work)	mid (Sonnet)	The summary feature in a separate copy of the code: storage, quote checking, AI wiring, screens, tests
workflow	mid (Sonnet)	The AgenticNodes workflow, all live experiments, scoring and figures
diag	mid (Sonnet)	Diagnosis of why 37% of facts were being discarded
literature review	general	Survey of open-source tools and research on long-form AI writing

Table 1. *Who did what. None of them could commit code or touch your main Chisel folder; the feature was built in separate working copies.*

What went wrong with the process, so you know: two helpers stopped at Claude Code's folder-trust prompt (I left those for you and for the already-trusted parent folders; I did not click through them); the main experiment helper's memory filled up and I had it keep notes in files; one helper reported documentation edits as done that were missing (it found and fixed that itself); the first "repeat" experiment silently replayed saved answers and had to be redone; our own cost estimate was ten times too low because we did not know the cheap model thinks invisibly; and, most important, **two of my own test designs were flawed** (the alias test and the first summaries test, sections 4 and 5). Those are reported as such.

Running the experiments in AgenticNodes, with layered checking

Every experiment was built as one AgenticNodes workflow so it runs the same way each time (Figure 3). Findings were judged by layers, cheapest first: plain rules in code, then Jev (a specialised yes/no checking model from TypeSafe, reached through OpenRouter), then a second ordinary AI model from a different company, then a person. In practice the plain rules settled about 80% of findings, Jev a handful, the second model none (it was never confident enough), and a person had to decide the rest. **That person was me, the manager agent, not you**; I say so wherever it applies and Appendix B gives you a sheet to spot-check my calls.

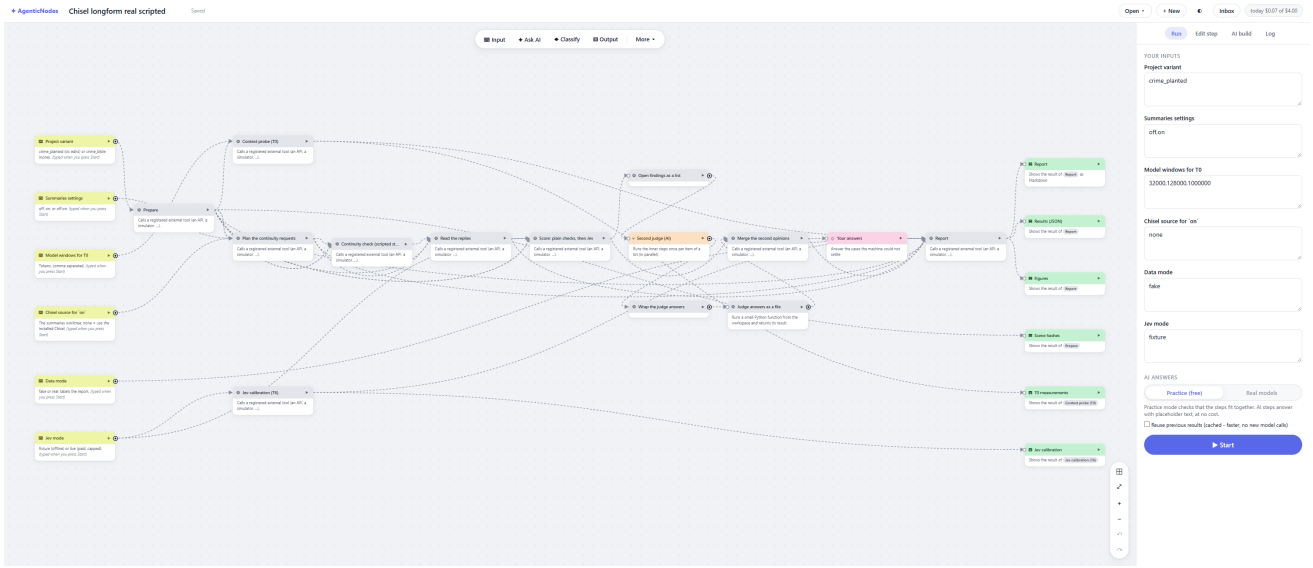


Figure 3. *The AgenticNodes canvas for the long-project workflow: prepare the project copy, measure what is sent, run the continuity checks, score them in layers, ask a person for the cases the machine cannot settle, write the report.*

Money: total spent on OpenRouter $3.33 of the 5.00 US dollars you allowed. Every paid call is in the ledger with its cost taken from the provider's response, never estimated. Only cheap models were used (DeepSeek v4 flash, GLM 4.7 flash, Mistral small as second judge, Jev).

2. The test material

Three public-domain novels from Project Gutenberg, split into Chisel projects (a part per book or part of the novel, a scene per chapter). They are test data only.

Book	Chapters	Words	Characters with notes
Crime and Punishment (Garnett)	41	202,746	25
The Brothers Karamazov	96	350,057	25
War and Peace	365	562,790	60

Table 2. *The three test books. Crime and Punishment has full ground truth; the other two have casts and name counts.*

Ground truth for Crime and Punishment was built so that answers do not rest on my impression: 40 facts, each with a word-for-word quote that code checked occurs exactly once in its chapter (380 automatic checks, all pass; I re-checked 10 of the facts against the book myself). From these we planted **six contradictions**, each a small change many chapters after the original fact, never visible inside the changed chapter alone, plus eight untouched control chapters:

Edit	What was changed	Where the true fact is
p02	The pawnbroker's flat: fourth floor became third (Part III ch. V)	Part I ch. I
p03	Luzhin's age: 45 became 52 (Part II ch. V)	Part I ch. III (his intended's letter)
p04	Svidrigaïlov married seven years became five (Part VI ch. IV)	Part III-IV
p05	Money Raskolnikov gave Katerina: twenty roubles became thirty (Part V ch. II)	Part II ch. VII
p08	Sonia's second cross: copper became silver (Part VI ch. VIII)	Part V ch. IV
p10	Dounia's eyes: black became blue (Part VI ch. V)	Part III ch. I

Table 3. *The six planted contradictions.*

The novel also contains **genuine slips of its own**, for example the merchant Vahrushin is "Vassily Ivanovitch" in Part I and "Afanasy Ivanovitch" in Part II. A checker that finds a verified slip is right, so it is scored as a "real slip", never as a false alarm. Katerina Ivanovna's habit of correcting the landlady's name (Amalia Ivanovna or Fyodorovna) is deliberate in the book, so flagging it is a false alarm. **A correction:** an earlier version of this report also listed "Luzhin's whiskers" and "Katerina's father's rank" as slips. Both were errors in my answer key (the flaxen whiskers belong to Lebeziatnikov, and a colonel is an officer), so they are removed; I re-scored every round and no catch and no false-alarm count changed.

3. What Chisel does today with a long book

This part uses no AI and costs nothing: Chisel's own planning code was run on each book to see exactly what it would send. (A "token" below is Chisel's own estimate of text size, one per four characters, about three-quarters of a word.)

It sends one chapter and the notes, whatever the size of the AI's window

The largest request in 216 trial runs was about 13,500 tokens. The same request was built whether the model could read 32 thousand, 128 thousand or a million tokens. For the three jobs that check your writing, **nothing from any other chapter was in the request** (0 of 36 requests each; we searched for any eight-word run from another chapter). Only drafting is different: it adds about 2,000 words of your own earlier prose, to copy your voice, not to check facts.

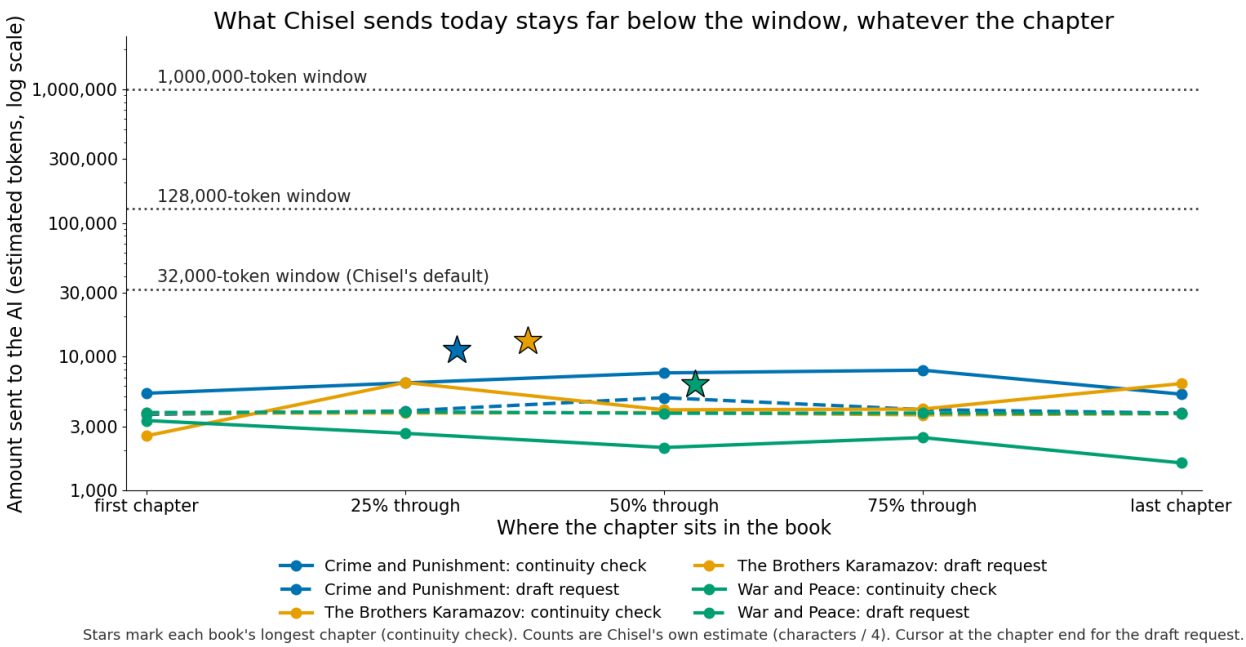
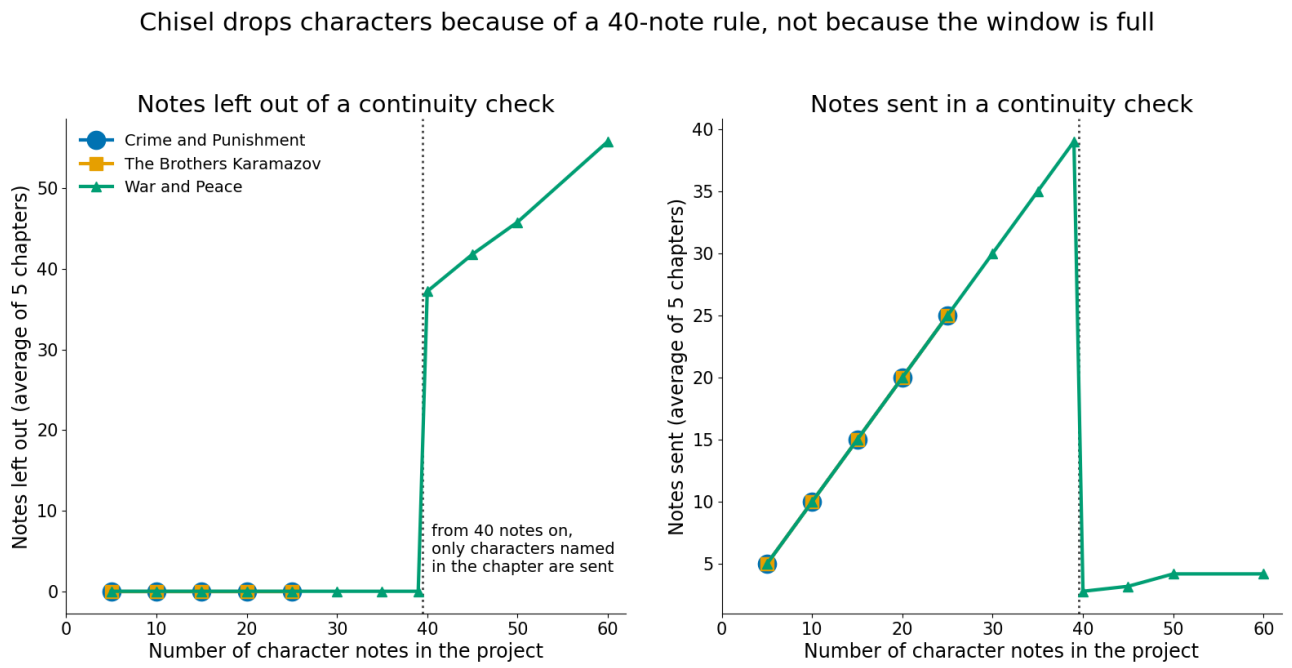


Figure 4. *What Chisel sends for a continuity check or a draft, at five places in each book. Every line sits far below every window size. Stars mark each book's longest chapter.*

The 40-notes cliff

Chisel sends every character note while a project has up to 39. At 40 or more it switches to sending only characters named in the chapter, and the change is abrupt: with 39 notes all 39 are sent, with 40 only about 3. In War and Peace's last chapter none of the 60 characters is named, so the check is sent no notes at all and the app skips the AI call.

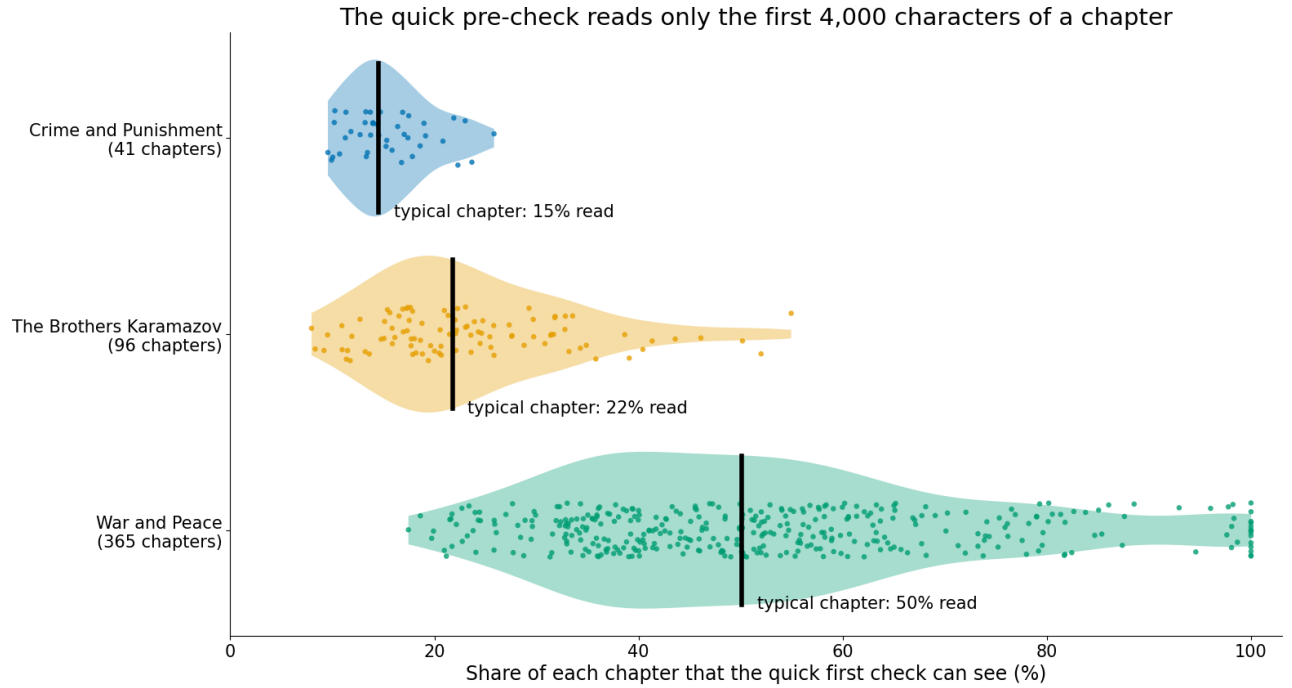


32,000-token window. Crime and Karamazov have only 25 notes (their lines sit under War and Peace's up to 25).
Even with every note padded to Chisel's 1,500-character cap, nothing was left out for lack of room (t0_cast_growth.csv).

Figure 5. *Notes left out of a continuity check as a project's cast grows. The cliff is at 40 notes.*

The quick pre-check only reads the start of a chapter

Chisel can run a fast Jev pre-check before the main check, but it reads only the first 4,000 characters of a chapter. In Crime and Punishment that is 15% of a typical chapter; four of our six hidden edits sit past that point. (In these projects the pre-check would not have run at all, because it only runs for projects with 1 to 20 notes that carry text.)



One dot = one chapter. A chapter shorter than 4,000 characters is read in full (100%). The pre-check only runs if the project has 1 to 20 notes with canon text.

Figure 6. *How much of each chapter the pre-check can see. One dot is one chapter.*

Names: perfect on one line, blind across a line break

Given a complete list of each character's names, Chisel's scanner found every mention written on one line (Crime 5,662 of 5,662; Karamazov 7,822 of 7,822; War and Peace 13,150 of 13,152). **Caveat I should have stated at the time:** the lists were generated from the same answer key the scanner was scored against, so this shows the scanner is accurate when the list is complete; it says nothing about how an author's list gets built. The one real gap is names split across two lines of the text file ("Rodion" at the end of a line, "Romanovitch" at the start of the next): Crime 147, Karamazov 227, War and Peace 249 mentions, never linked as one name. That matters only for hard-wrapped manuscripts like these Gutenberg files.

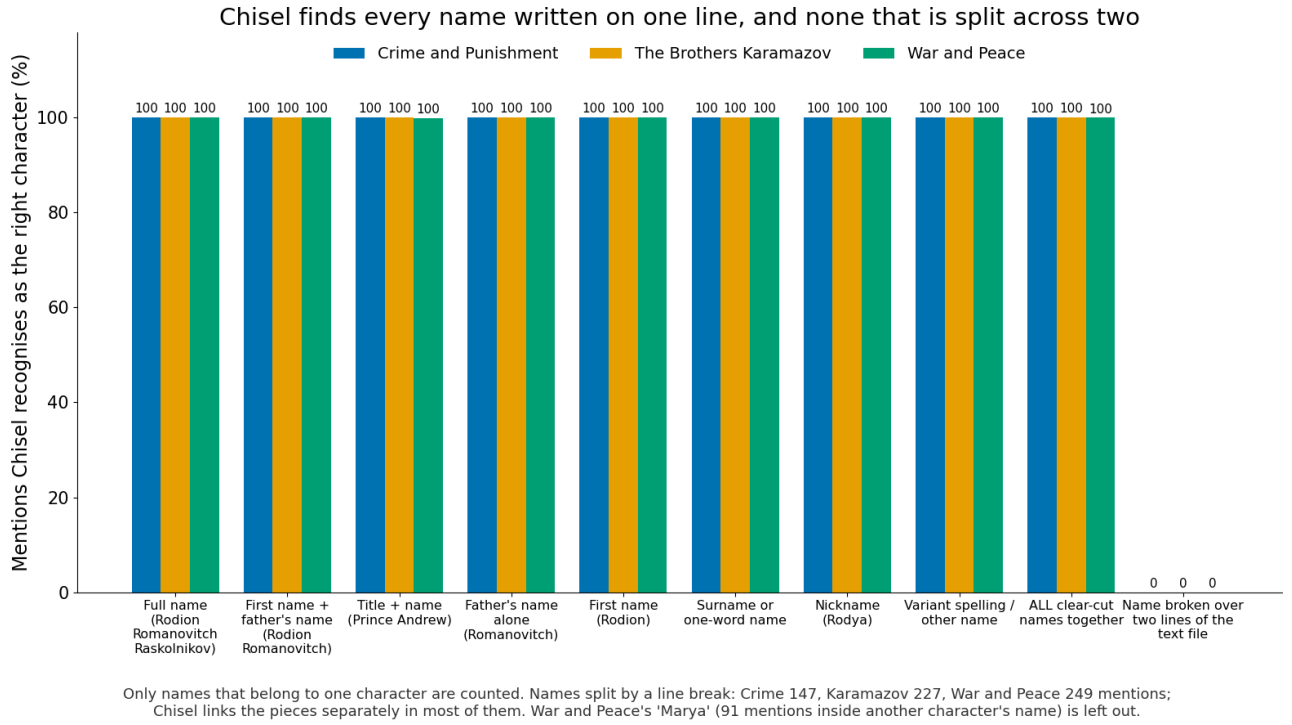


Figure 7. *Share of name mentions Chisel recognises, by kind of name.*

4. Building the summary memory

What others have done

A literature and open-source survey (standard search only; several tools I asked about were not checked) found that nobody has a settled answer, but a consistent set of ideas: NovelCrafter (closed source) keeps an editable summary of about 80 words per scene and warns that summaries go stale; SillyTavern's summarising extensions tie each summary to the text it covers and fall back to an earlier one when that text changes; OpenAI's book-summarising work and the BooookScore study summarise sections, then summaries of summaries, and find that a running summary is cheaper but makes more mistakes; the NoCha benchmark found that even with a whole novel in view, leading models answered only about 56% of true-or-false claims about it correctly, so a bigger window alone does not fix continuity. We borrowed: short fixed-size summaries, an editable and lockable record, a marker that says when a scene changed after its summary, a hierarchy (scene, part, book), and testing summaries by asking questions of them.

What was built

- **One small file per chapter** in a visible folder (like comments and drafts, not the hidden rebuildable cache, because you may edit it and it costs money to make). It travels with the chapter when you move, rename, trash or restore it.
- **Contents:** a summary of up to 80 words; the characters present and their state at the end; facts, each with a quote from the chapter; open questions. Code checks every quote and every name against the chapter; a fact whose quote is not really there is dropped and listed. Nothing is saved until you press Accept; nothing is written silently.
- **Freshness:** each summary remembers a fingerprint of its chapter; if you edit the chapter it is marked out of date, never regenerated by itself. You can lock one you have edited.
- **Use in AI requests:** a short "story so far" (part summaries for earlier parts, chapter summaries for the current part), the history of the characters in the scene, and a list of verified facts, all inside Chisel's existing size budget and listed in the "What was sent" report. A project with no summaries sends exactly what it sent before (locked by tests).
- **Screens:** a Summary card for the open chapter, a review dialog, a Summaries panel for the whole book with a cost estimate shown first, and a notice that tells you when your book has outgrown what the AI can see (section 8).

The build finished with 1,834 automated tests passing (up from 1,648 before we started) and 217 front-end tests. One flaky terminal-screen test that was already failing before we began still fails occasionally under load.

First real run: it threw away 37% of the facts

On Crime and Punishment, 128 of 344 facts the model offered were discarded because the quote check could not find their quote. A diagnosis helper re-ran three chapters and read every discard: the facts were almost all true. The model often glued two real passages together with "..." or ended a quote with a full stop where the book has a comma, and our check demanded one unbroken, exact piece. We changed the check to accept ordered pieces that each really occur (at most 2,000 characters apart), changed the prompt to ask for one unbroken passage, and added one automatic retry. Result: **37.2% discarded became 4.1%**, 50 true facts rescued. Because a looser rule is risky, I tested it myself: of 400 real passages it accepted all 400, and of 1,600 deliberately falsified quotes (a word swapped, pieces reversed, pieces too far apart, a passage from another chapter) it accepted none. I also read 12 rescued facts against their quotes: 11 were fully supported, one slightly over-stated. The check proves a quote exists; it does not prove the quote supports the fact. That limit remains.

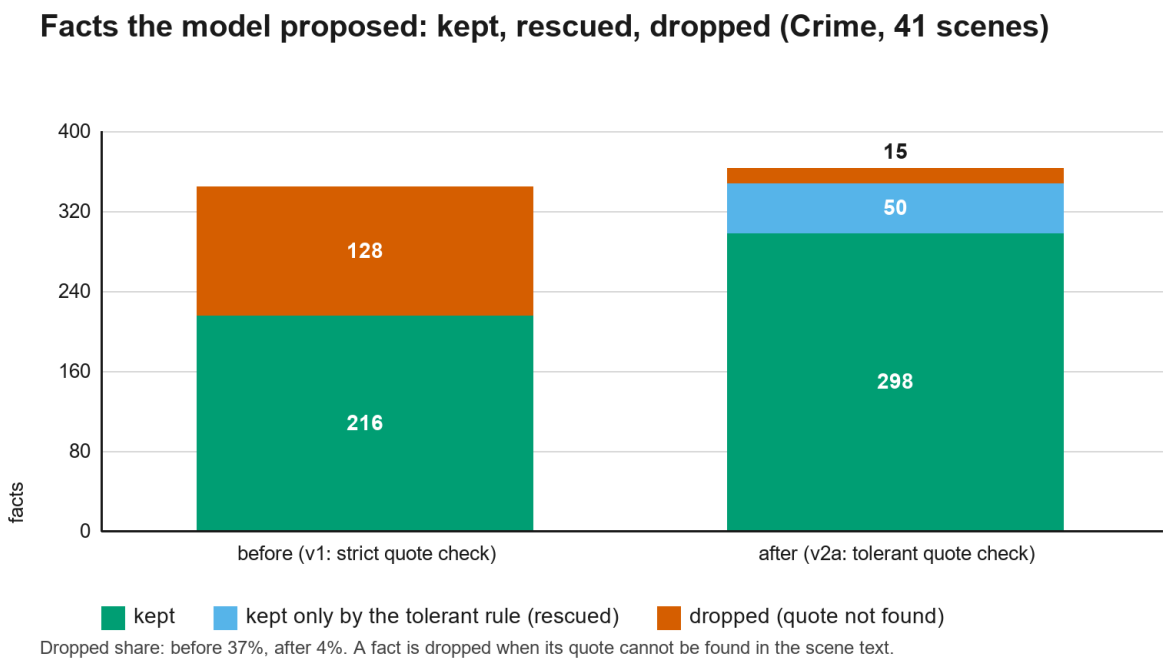


Figure 8. *Facts kept, rescued and discarded before and after the fix (Crime and Punishment, 41 chapters).*

The cheap model that thinks too much

The cheap model used (DeepSeek v4 flash) is a "reasoning" model: before answering it produces thousands of hidden thinking chunks that are billed. A 90-word summary used 3,000 to 20,000 of them, about 47 seconds per chapter and ten times our cost estimate. One alias-finder call ran 18 minutes. We added a setting **reasoning: default / low / off** for the checking tools (never for drafting or chat) and reported it in "What was sent". Switching thinking off made summaries 3.4 times cheaper and more than twice as fast, at a small quality cost:

Crime and Punishment, 41 chapters	Thinking on (default)	Thinking off
Cost	8.8 cents	2.6 cents
Seconds per chapter	46.9	17.4
Facts kept	348	306
Facts discarded	15 (4.1%)	33 (9.7%)
Wrong character names listed	9	24
Summaries needing a retry	1	2

Table 4. *Thinking on versus off for the summary step (same model, same chapters).*

At book scale thinking off is the practical choice: War and Peace's 365 summaries took 32 minutes and 17 cents. Chapter summaries that ran past the word limit used to be cut in the middle of a sentence; they are now cut at a sentence end.

What an 80-word summary can and cannot hold

We measured whether the key value of each of 40 true facts ("forty-five", "silver", "fourth") survives into the summary text, fact list or character states. After the fix, **22.5% did** (12.5% before). Numbers and places survive sometimes (33% and 50%); colours and family relations never did (0 of 15). This is a plain consequence of length: a summary tells you what happened, not the colour of someone's eyes. Those belong in the character's note.

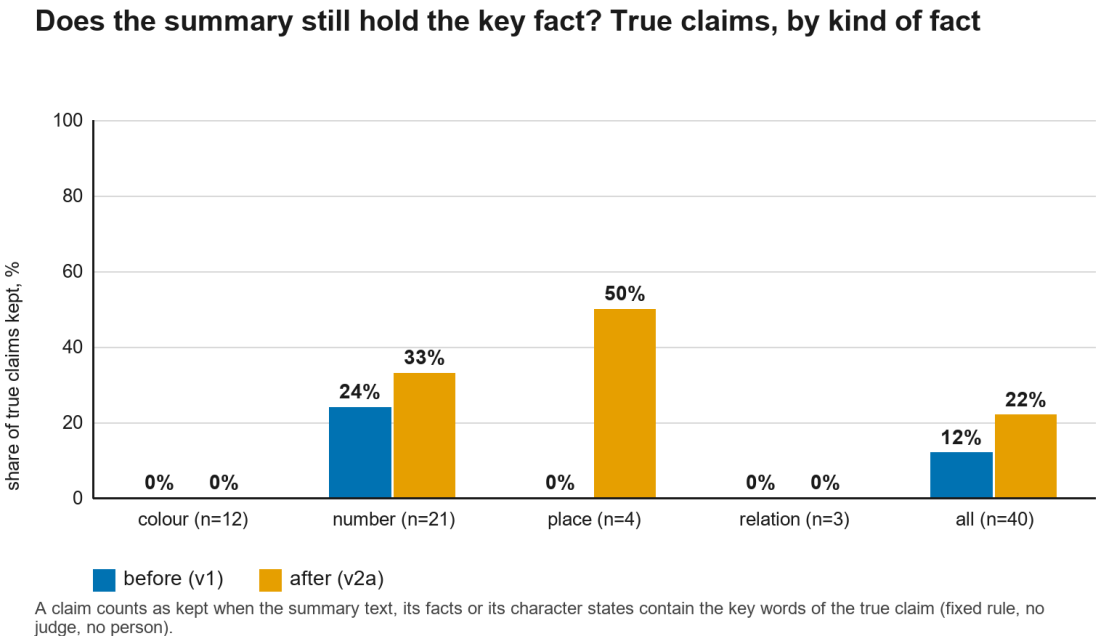


Figure 9. *Share of true facts whose key value is still in the summary, by kind of fact, before and after the fix.*

The alias finder returned nothing, and my test premise was wrong

We tried Chisel's alias finder on Crime and Punishment with the characters' nicknames removed. In all six sampled chapters it returned nothing: with thinking on it burned 14,000 to 78,000 hidden chunks per call; with thinking off it answered quickly, but the model's character positions were wrong, so Chisel's own validation discarded every suggestion. Two lessons. First, the tool is fragile with these models and a better design is to let the code find the quoted words in the text instead of trusting the model's positions. Second, **my test was built on a wrong assumption**: the finder is designed to spot descriptive references ("the old pawnbroker"), not to learn nicknames like "Rodya". Nothing in Chisel currently discovers a character's name forms. That is a feature gap worth a decision.

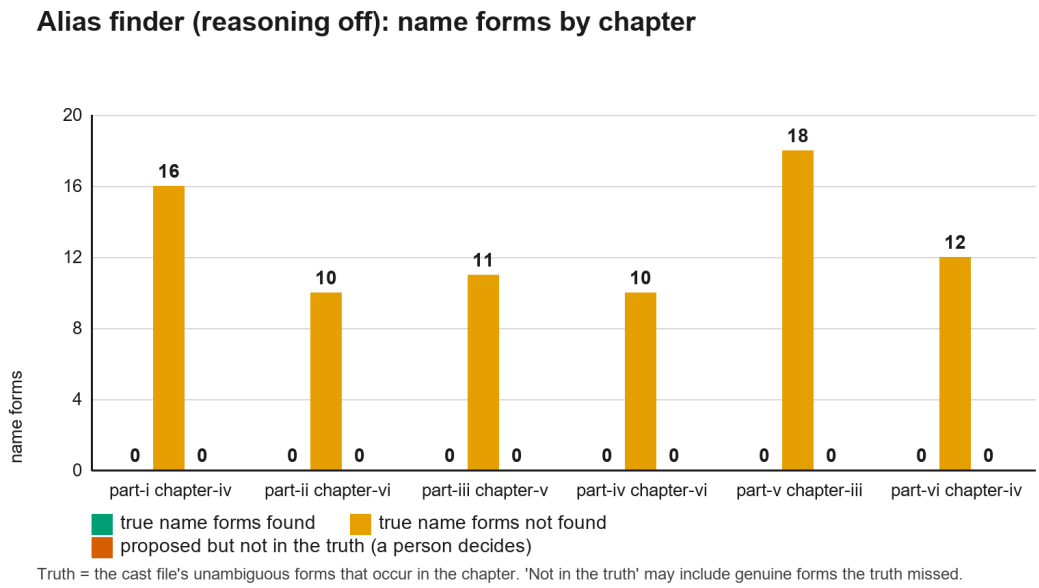


Figure 10. *Alias finder with thinking off: true name forms found per chapter (none).*

5. Does it help find contradictions?

The conditions

Label	What the AI is given besides the chapter	Meaning
A	Character notes as they are today (one line each)	Today's behaviour
B	Notes that also contain every verified fact, written by hand	The best a diligent author could do (an upper bound)
C	Notes + summaries of earlier chapters (round 1)	First attempt at the new feature
C2	C + an instruction that the summaries are established fact	Round 2
D	Notes + a list of verified facts about the characters in the scene + the instruction	Round 2 and 3
E	Both the summaries and the fact list + the instruction	Round 2 and 3

Table 5. *The experimental conditions. Each runs the same 6 edited chapters and 8 untouched control chapters.*

Round 1: summaries shown to the model did not help

With the cheap model allowed to think (default), the notes alone caught 0 of 6 hidden contradictions in two separate runs, the hand-written fact notes (B) caught 4 of 6, and notes plus summaries (C) caught 0 of 6 in two runs. With thinking off the numbers were lower still (B caught 1). The second model, GLM, returned no usable answer at all in its default mode (9 of 9 calls used all 30,000 chunks of thinking and produced no text); with thinking off it worked but often wrote an endless list of findings until it hit the size cap, and Chisel then discarded the whole reply.

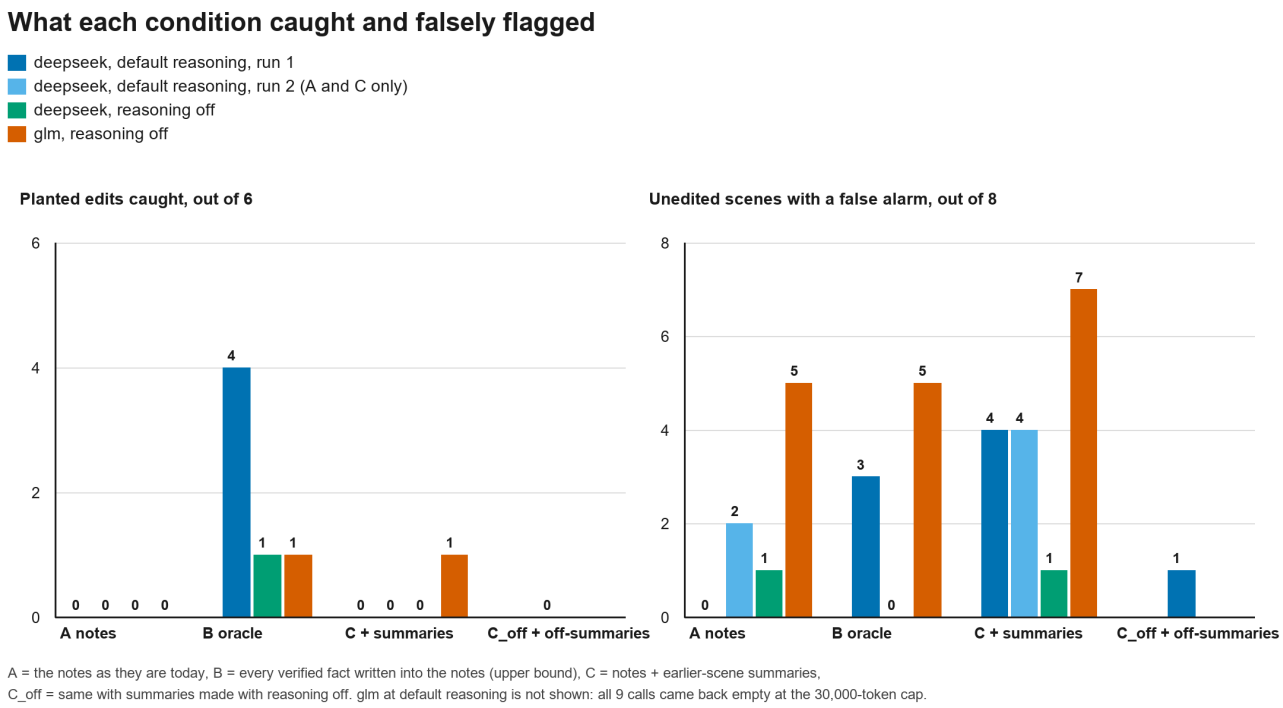


Figure 11. *Round 1, final (after my review of the waiting findings): planted edits caught and untouched chapters with a false alarm. B (hand-written facts) is the only condition that did well, and only when the model could think.*

Honest reading of the noise: repeating exactly the same run changed about 30% of DeepSeek's scene outcomes (21 of 70). A difference of one catch, or of two false-alarm chapters, between two conditions is inside that noise.

My own mistake, found by reading the code

The first summaries test was **confounded**. Chisel's continuity instructions told the model it was given "entity canon" and the current chapter and should find places where the chapter breaks established canon. They never said that the new story-so-far section is established fact too, and only the summary prose was sent, not the quote-checked facts, which are what a contradiction needs. So round 1 shows that summaries shown without explanation did not help, not that summaries cannot help. We fixed both: a short instruction that is added only when summaries are present, and a ledger of verified facts about the characters in the scene.

Round 2: with the instruction and the fact list, still no clear gain

The instruction did change behaviour: DeepSeek began quoting the earlier statement it relied on ("earlier: ...") in 30% to 67% of its findings, and on the changed roubles it produced exactly the finding we wanted ("Earlier: Raskolnikov gave Katerina twenty roubles. The scene claims thirty.") in one repetition out of two. But it did not reduce false alarms and did not catch more than about one edit. The helper also found a **design gap that capped the experiment**: the fact list was built for only the first three characters in a chapter, and for two edits (Luzhin's age, Sonia's cross) the changed character was not among them, so no model could have found them.

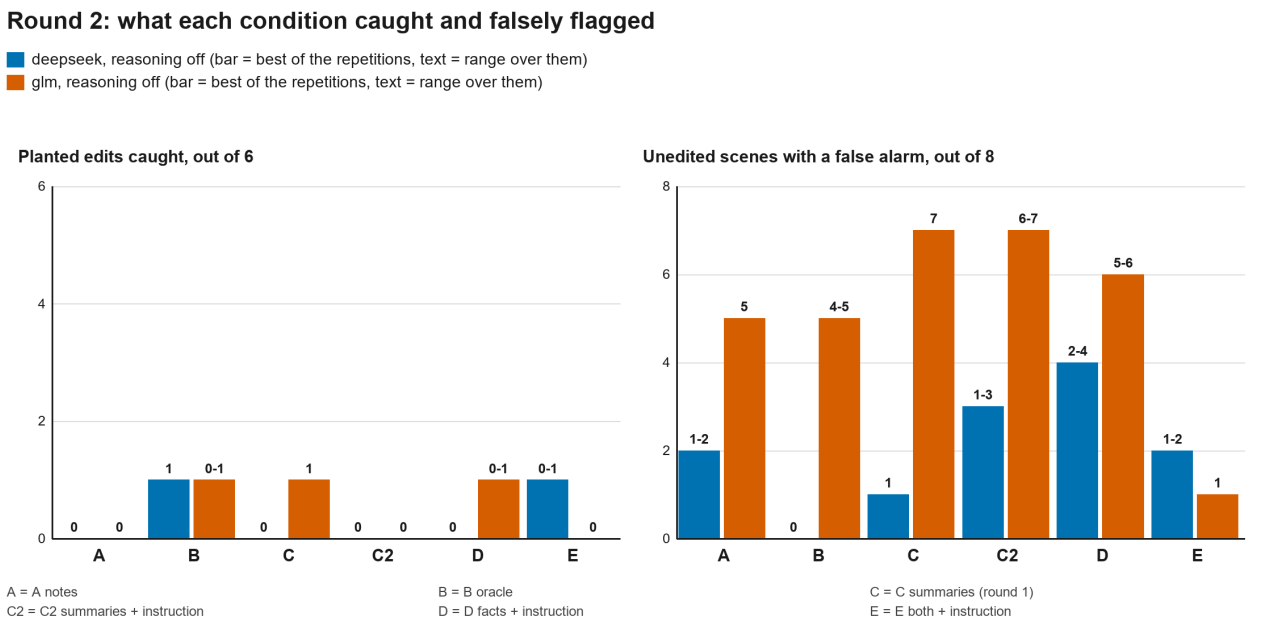


Figure 12. Round 2 (thinking off): catches and false alarms per condition. Bars show the best of two repetitions; the text shows the range.

Round 2: which planted edits each condition caught

dark green = caught in both repetitions light green = caught in one orange = a finding waits for the manager grey = missed

	A deepseek	B deepseek	C deepseek	C2 deepseek	D deepseek	E deepseek	A glm	B glm	C glm	C2 glm	D glm	E glm
edit p02	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed
edit p03	missed	both	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	one	missed	missed	missed	missed
edit p04	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed
edit p05	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	one	missed	missed	both	missed	one	missed
edit p08	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed
edit p10	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed	missed

A, B = round 1 (unchanged code) plus one extra repetition; C = round 1's summaries; C2 summaries + instruction, D facts ledger + instruction, E both + instruction. 'both' with one repetition only (C) means caught in that run.

Figure 13. Which planted edit each condition caught (round 2). Most cells are grey: missed.

Round 3: the fair test

Two reasons round 2 could not show a gain: the fact list skipped characters, and every round-2 run had thinking switched off, where even the hand-written notes caught only one edit (they caught four with thinking on). For round 3 the builder widened the fact list to up to eight characters, and we ran D and E, with the model allowed to think, next to B for reference. The result was the same: with thinking on and the fact list covering up to eight characters, the facts list and the summaries together caught 0 of 6 for the right reason, while the hand-written notes (B) again caught 4 of 6. A free check made before paying for those runs had already said why. For each edit we asked whether the original fact was even present in the history Chisel would send. **It was present for one edit out of six** (the roubles, and only in the summary text, not the fact list). For the other five, the summaries never wrote the fact down: nothing says "Luzhin is forty-five", "her eyes are black", "a copper cross" or "the fourth floor". The summaries record what happens; continuity depends on stable details. The wider fact list fixed a real gap (two edited characters had been skipped) but not the one that decides the outcome. Two further DeepSeek findings quoted the edited sentences but for the wrong reason (for example it quoted "fifty-two years" and said no age existed to compare); I did not count them as catches.

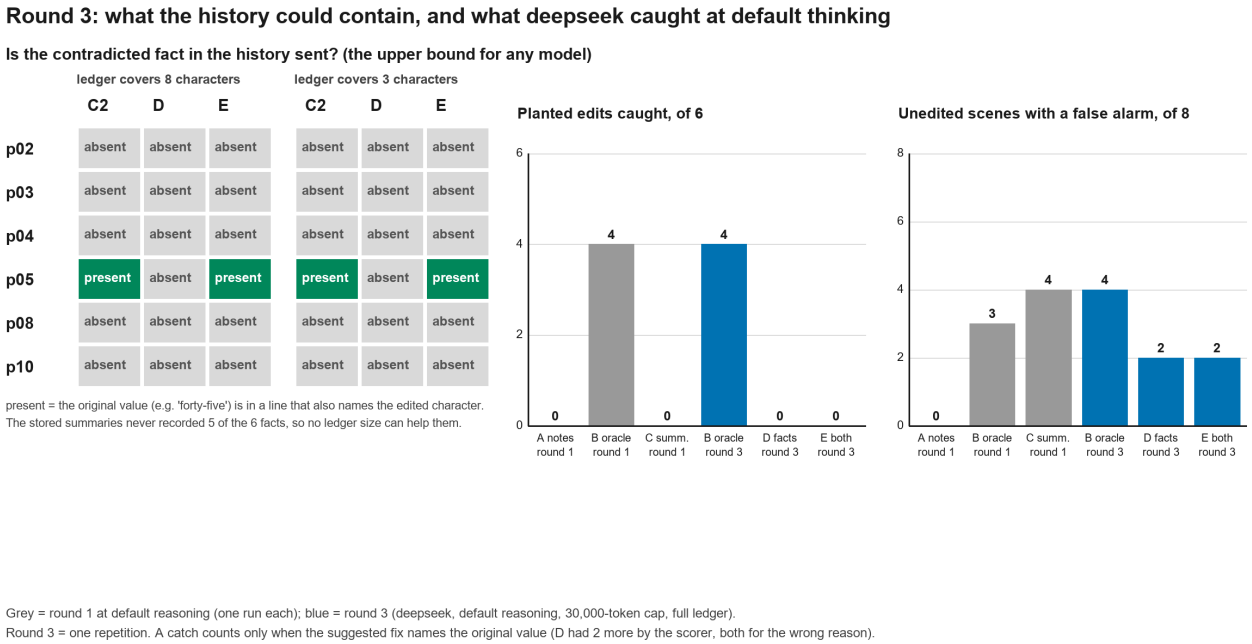


Figure 14. *Round 3. Left: is the contradicted fact even in the history that would be sent? Only the roubles (p05) are, with summaries or both; the fact list alone has none of them. Right: planted edits caught and false alarms for round 1's default-thinking runs (grey) and round 3 (blue). A catch counts only when the finding names the original value.*

Round 4: can Chisel's own canon tool do it?

The ceiling check pointed at the shape of what is recorded: events, not stable details. Chisel already has a tool for stable details (it reads a chapter and proposes new facts for each character's note, which the author accepts or rejects). We ran it over the 41 chapters in order, kept a proposal only if its quoted evidence is really in the chapter (standing in for the author's review), and snapshotted the notes after every chapter so each check sees only earlier chapters. **Result: of 621 facts proposed, 610 (98%) failed the quote check**, because the tool asks for "a brief quote or paraphrase" and the model answers with one long string mixing quotation and its own narration. The 11 survivors were no story bible, and the check with those notes caught 0 of 6, with thinking on or off.

Replaying every proposal without the quote check shows the loss is partly real: the right fact existed for three edits (the fourth floor, the seven-year marriage, the twenty roubles, though filed under Raskolnikov rather than Katerina) and was never proposed for the other three (Luzhin's age, the copper cross, Dounia's eyes). Accepting everything also made Raskolnikov's note 15,000 characters, ten times the cap the tool uses when it proposes, and the request nearly 19,000 tokens. Even with two of the facts sitting in the notes, a thinking-off run caught nothing. So the fix has two parts: ask for one verbatim quote per fact (the same lesson as the summaries), and a model that is allowed to think when it checks. Neither was tried together.

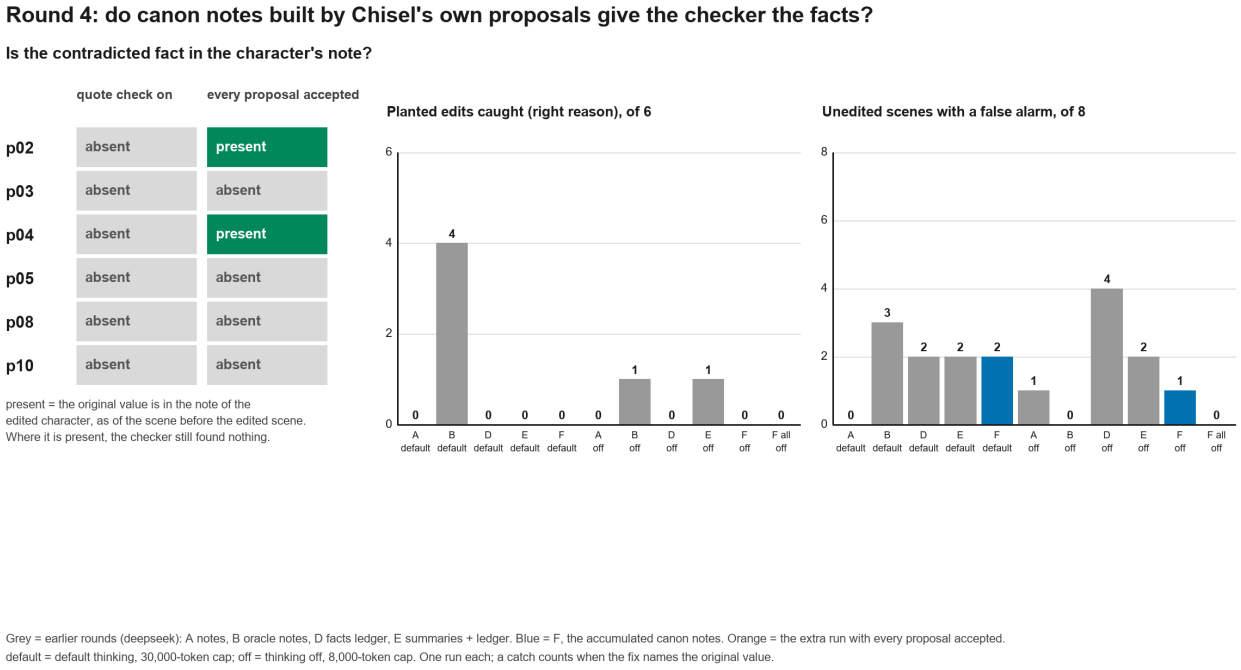


Figure 15. *Round 4. Left: is the contradicted fact in the character's note? With the quote check on, never; if every proposal is accepted, two of six (a third is filed under another character). Right: catches and false alarms next to the earlier conditions.*

Round 5: the fixed canon tool

Following the recommendation above, I had the canon tool changed (committed on its own branch): each proposed fact now comes with its own word-for-word quote, which code checks against the chapter, and the prompt asks first for stable details (ages, looks, amounts, durations, possessions with colour or material, places, relationships, habits). We repeated round 4 exactly. **Of 519 facts proposed over the 41 chapters, 492 (95%) passed the check**, against 11 of 621 before. It took 8 minutes and 4 cents.

The free ceiling check now reads five of six: the contradicted fact is in the edited character's own note ("is forty-five years old" in Luzhin's, "has a copper cross that belonged to Lizaveta" in Sonia's, "has almost black eyes" in Dounia's, "lives in a flat on the fourth storey" in Alyona's), and the sixth (the twenty roubles) is in Raskolnikov's note, naming Katerina. We then ran the continuity check on those notes (condition F), two runs at each thinking setting. **It caught 2 and 3 of 6 with thinking on and 2 and 1 with thinking off, for the right reason; the round-4 version caught none.** The catches were the short attribute lines: Luzhin's age in all four runs, the copper cross in three, the fourth floor in one. Never caught for the right reason: the seven years, the twenty roubles, the eye colour. (One near-miss,

not counted: the checker flagged the edited "after five years" sentence against a different recorded fact, "eight years ago"; the book does say both, so the number mismatch was real but not the planted one.)

The price was false alarms: 5 or 6 of the 8 untouched chapters with thinking on, and 7 or 8 with thinking off, where the checker wrote 80 to 120 findings across 14 chapters. Reading them, most say "the notes do not establish X" about something the book simply tells us (Raskolnikov's article, his faith, Dounia's revolver): the check treats silence in the notes as a contradiction. That looks like a problem with the checking instructions, not the notes, so the obvious fix was a one-sentence change to those instructions (round 6, next). Real slips of the book matched: the roubles, and once "rather early".

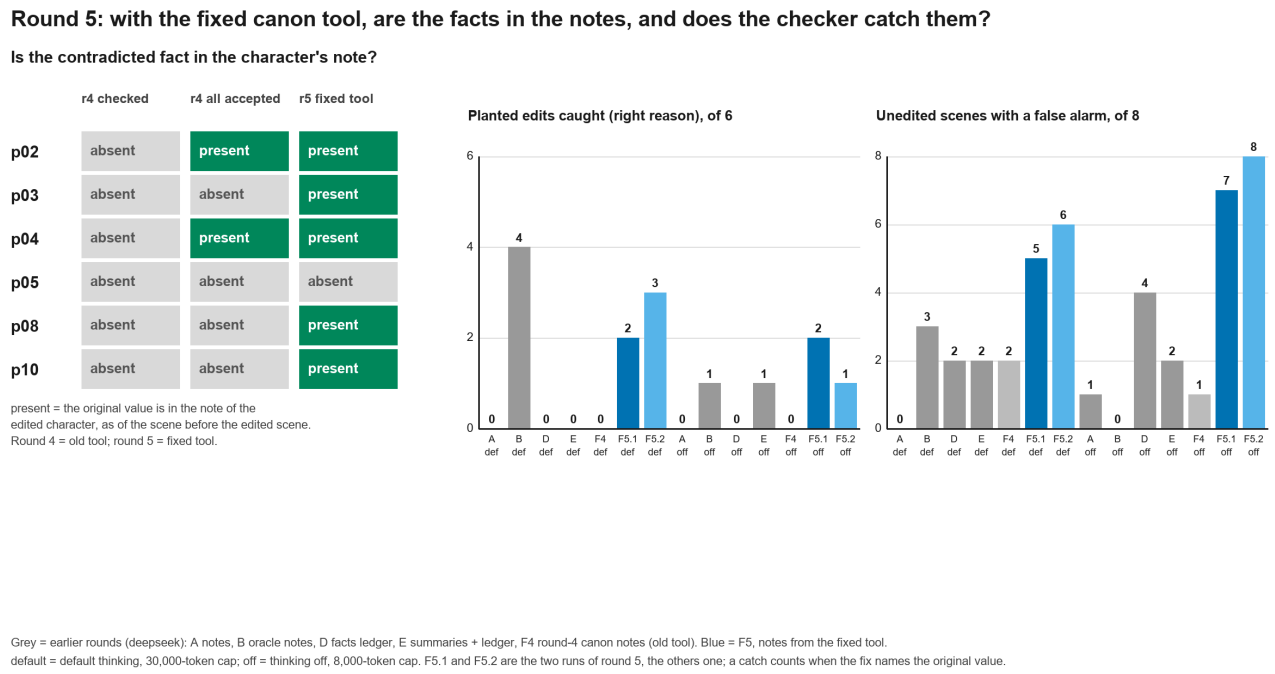


Figure 16. *Round 5. Left: the contradicted fact is now in the character's note for five of six edits with the fixed tool (round 4 with the quote check: none). Right: catches and false alarms; blue is the fixed tool, grey the earlier conditions.*

Round 6: the one-sentence fix that did not work

The obvious fix was to tell the checker that a contradiction needs two statements that cannot both be true, and that something the notes do not mention is not a contradiction. I wrote the criterion for success before running anything: false-alarm chapters at most 0.7 times the old prompt's, and catches no more than half a catch lower. Three attempts followed, and this is an honest account of all three. **Attempt 1** (default thinking, five runs per prompt): false alarms fell from 4.2 to 3.0 of 8, but catches fell from 3.2 to 2.0, so the criterion failed, and three of the five new-prompt runs barely thought at all, because the model provider's behaviour seemed to change mid-session, which made the comparison unreliable. **Attempt 2** (thinking pinned to a low level): void. The one new-prompt run used up its whole token budget thinking, returned almost nothing, and cost 49 cents, six times the price of a comparable run; I stopped it before it could break your spending cap. **Attempt 3** (thinking switched off, ten runs alternating old and new so any provider drift hits both alike, every run valid): **the new prompt made false alarms worse, 5.4 of 8 chapters against 1.2**, and catches stayed near zero for both (0.8 and 0.4 of 6). The wording of the findings did change (the "notes do not establish X" style fell from 33% to 22%), but the model simply raised other kinds of false alarm in the same chapters.

So I discarded the change and did not ship it. A broader lesson is in the numbers: the same old prompt produced 7 to 8 false-alarm chapters in one session and 0 to 2 in another, so results from different sessions cannot be compared; only runs interleaved within one session can. The next idea, tested in round 7 below, was a "two-quote rule": a finding must quote the scene and also quote the conflicting line from the notes, and code checks both. A finding of the form "the notes do not establish X" cannot satisfy it. It is the same trick that fixed the canon tool.

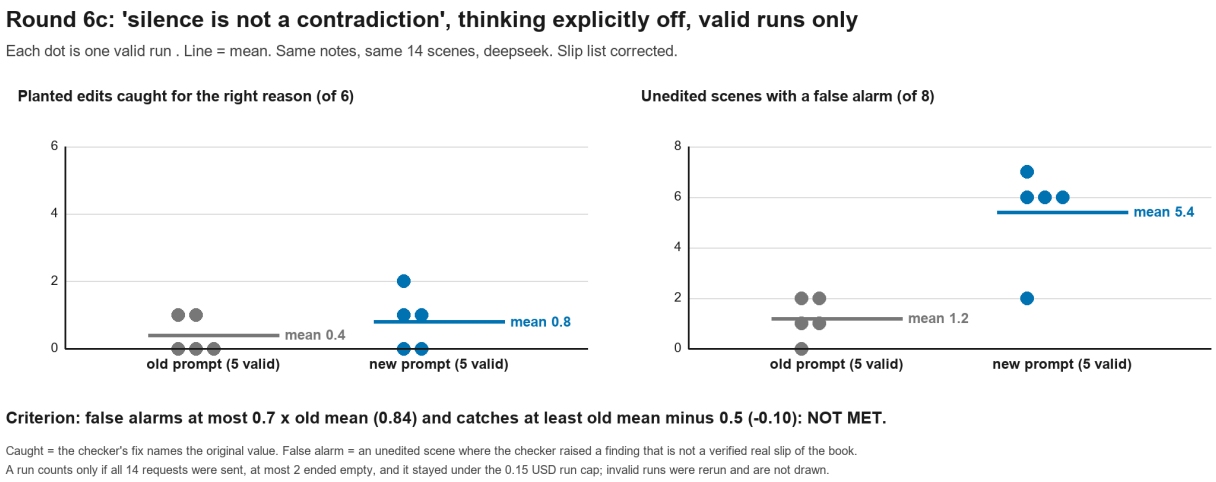


Figure 17. *Round 6, attempt 3 (thinking off, ten valid runs alternating old and new prompt). Each dot is one run. The new prompt (blue) raised false alarms and did not catch more.*

Round 7: the two-quote rule, a real but mixed result

I built the two-quote rule (committed on its own branch, not merged). Every continuity finding must now carry two quotes: the exact text of the scene, and the exact line of the character notes it conflicts with. Code checks both against what was actually sent, and checks they are not the same text. A finding that fails is left out and listed with a plain reason, so a finding of the form "the notes do not establish X" cannot survive: there is no notes line to quote. The success criterion was written first: false-alarm chapters at most 0.7 times the old check's, and catches no more than half a catch lower. I tested it with thinking switched off, five valid runs each of the old and the new check, run alternately so provider drift hits both.

Result: false alarms fell by 40%, from 7.4 to 4.4 of 8 untouched chapters, and findings per chapter fell from 5.1 to 1.6. That part of the criterion was met. **But catches fell from 1.8 to 1.0 of 6**, a little below the allowed floor of 1.3, so the criterion as written was missed by 0.3. The reason is one edit: the copper-cross change was caught in four of five old runs and in none of the new ones. I checked whether the code check was removing real catches, and it was not: in every new run the catches scored from the model's raw reply, before any verification, were the same as after. The code dropped only 17% of what the model returned (12 invented scene quotes, 9 invented notes quotes, 1 repeated quote). Most of the reduction came from the model writing far fewer findings under the new instructions, and for one edit that meant not raising it. Both arms caught only the Luzhin age edit reliably.

So this is a trade-off, not a win and not a failure, and the decision whether to adopt it is yours. In its favour: the author sees, for every finding, the exact line of their own notes it contradicts, and unverifiable findings are visibly left out; false alarms are much lower. Against: a six-edit test cannot say whether the lost catch is chance (one edit decides the verdict), and 4.4 false-alarm chapters out of 8

is still high. As always the numbers come from one model, one book and thinking off, and the old arm itself swung from 1.2 to 7.4 false-alarm chapters between two sessions, so nothing here can be pooled with earlier rounds.

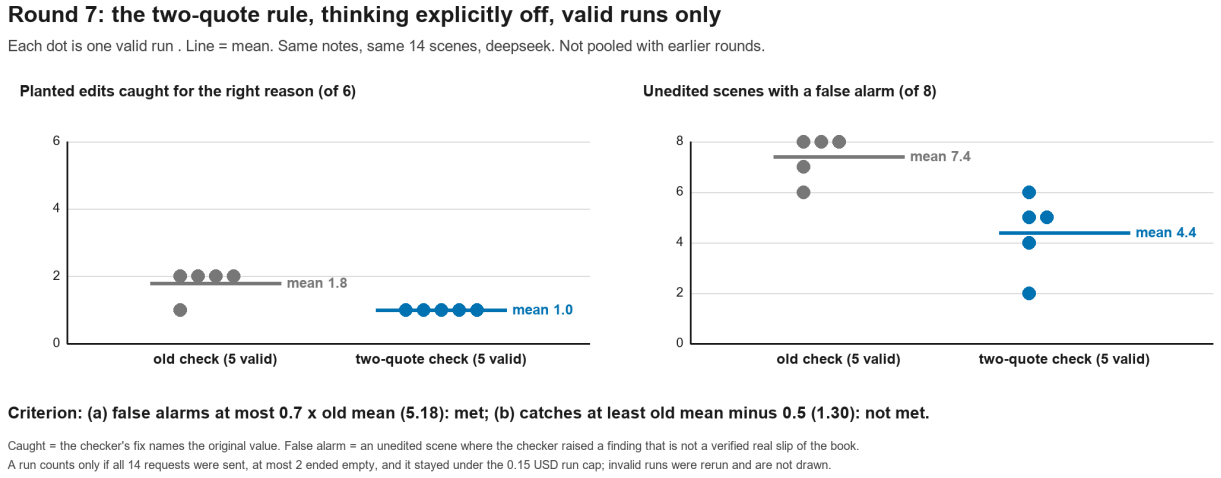


Figure 18. *Round 7 (thinking off, five valid runs per check, alternating). The two-quote check (blue) cut false alarms but caught fewer edits; each dot is one run.*

What the AI found that was not a hidden edit

Across rounds 1 to 5, 145 findings on the edited chapters could not be settled by plain rules and came to me. None of them was a hidden edit. Almost all were the model misreading the book: for example calling Svidrigaïlov still married although his wife is dead; comparing two different money offers (ten thousand through Raskolnikov, thirty thousand "all my money" later) as if they should match; or writing, in its own finding, "this is fine, no contradiction". Several flagged the edited sentence for the wrong reason (for instance quoting "fifty-two years" while saying no age existed to compare); I did not count those as catches.

Genuine slips in the novel itself (verified against the text; the checkers get credit for finding these): Raskolnikov gives "twenty roubles, I think" in Part II but Razumihin says he "flung away all the twenty-five" in Part III; in Part VI the police officer says "you are rather early" at dusk, which the translator's own footnote calls an oversight by Dostoevsky (easy: the footnote is in the chapter text); and Vahrushin's first name changes between Parts I and II (never found by any checker). One more is probable but unverified: Bakaleyev's lodging is found by Luzhin in Part II and by Razumihin in Part VI. The roubles slip was found mainly by the hand-written notes (B) and by the notes built by the fixed canon tool; "rather early" turned up in a few runs. In rounds 1 to 3, findings about Luzhin's whiskers and Katerina's father had been counted as real slips: they were not (see the correction in section 2).

6. Checking the checkers

- **Jev** agreed with the known true or false label on **74 of 76 claims (97.4%)** when judging claims against the 3,000 characters of the book around the fact (4 claims it declined on its own rules: two needing counting, two dates). That clears the 85% bar we set. It is an easier job than judging a summary, so it is promising, not proven.
- **The second ordinary AI judge (Mistral small)** settled nothing: its confidence is self-reported and the rule never accepts that alone. It also answered "no" to 61 of 62 summary claims. A judge that

always says no tells you little.

- **Plain rules** did most of the work and are the most trustworthy layer: does the finding name the right character and quote the edited words. They are also why we insisted on word-for-word quotes everywhere.
- **Repeat noise** is the biggest hazard: the same model, same inputs, flipped about a third of outcomes. Any single run of these checkers should be treated as a rough sample.
- **A person** was needed for the leftovers, which means this approach does not remove human review; it concentrates it.

7. The two big books

Summaries of all 96 Karamazov chapters and all 365 War and Peace chapters were made with thinking off, three at a time, with no chapter left unsummarised.

	Karamazov	War and Peace
Chapters / parts	96 / 13	365 / 17
Cost	6 cents	17 cents
Wall time	8.5 minutes	32 minutes
Words per summary (average)	63.5	59.4
Facts discarded by the quote check	7.2%	4.0%
Summaries cut at the word limit	8%	3.8%
All summaries together, as share of the book's words	5.0%	10.0%
Time to scan the whole book (status, scale check)	under 0.5 s	under 2 s

Table 6. *Summarising the big books. A 560,000-word novel for 17 cents and half an hour.*

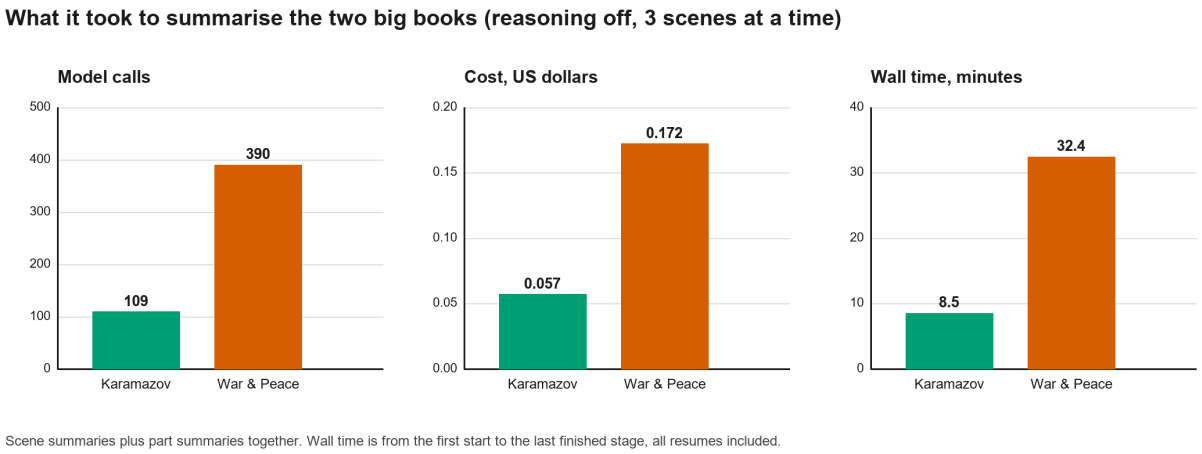


Figure 19. *Calls, cost and time to summarise the two big books.*

The story-so-far is tiny next to the book

Earlier parts are one block each. At the last chapter of War and Peace the story-so-far is about 5,000 tokens for a book of roughly 750,000. With the 2,500-token cap, **82% of the earlier chapters (298 of 364) are not represented at all**, and the part that disappears first is the beginning, where facts get planted. A main character's history costs about 1,100 to 1,700 tokens for five scenes however long the book is, which leaves about 95% of the earlier scenes that name a War and Peace lead out.

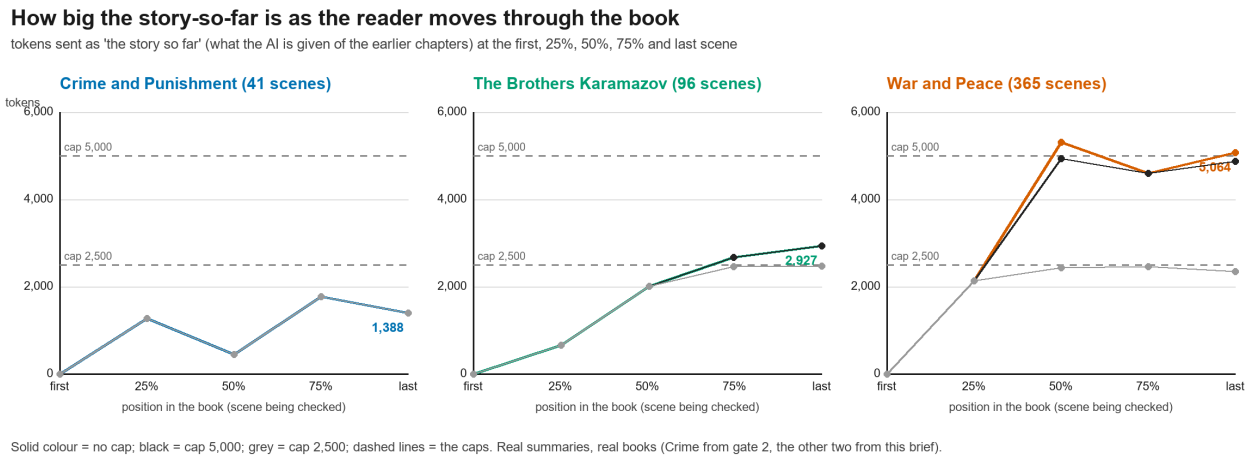


Figure 20. *How big the story-so-far is as the reader moves through each book, with and without a size cap.*

Summaries often leave a main character out

Of the scenes that name a main character, 75% (Karamazov) and 76% (War and Peace) have that character in the scene's summary; Ivan Karamazov is missing from 15 of the 54 chapters that name him, and both Natásha and Sónya are missing from a chapter that names each of them 23 times. Cheap summaries do not carry names reliably.

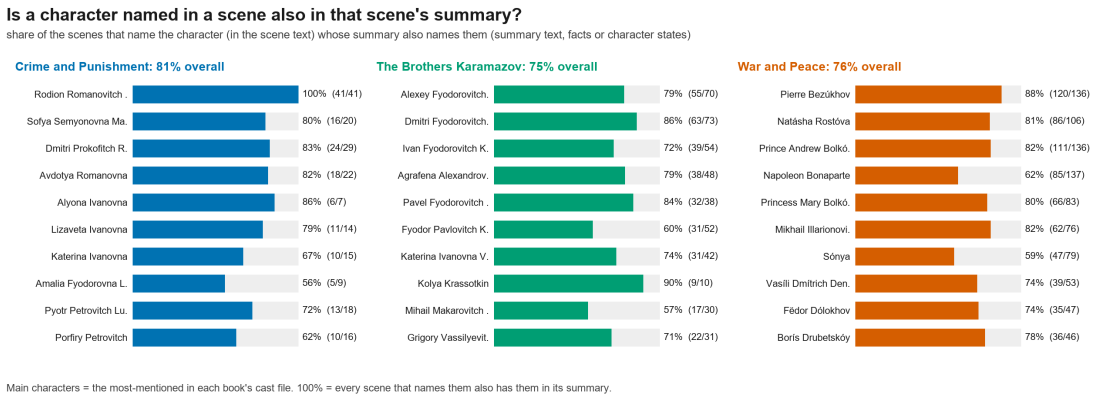


Figure 21. *Share of scenes naming a character in which that character also appears in the scene's summary.*

8. What the author sees

These are real screenshots of the new screens running on the Crime and Punishment project with its 41 real summaries (the review dialog shows a canned stand-in proposal, not a real model answer, so its text is rough).

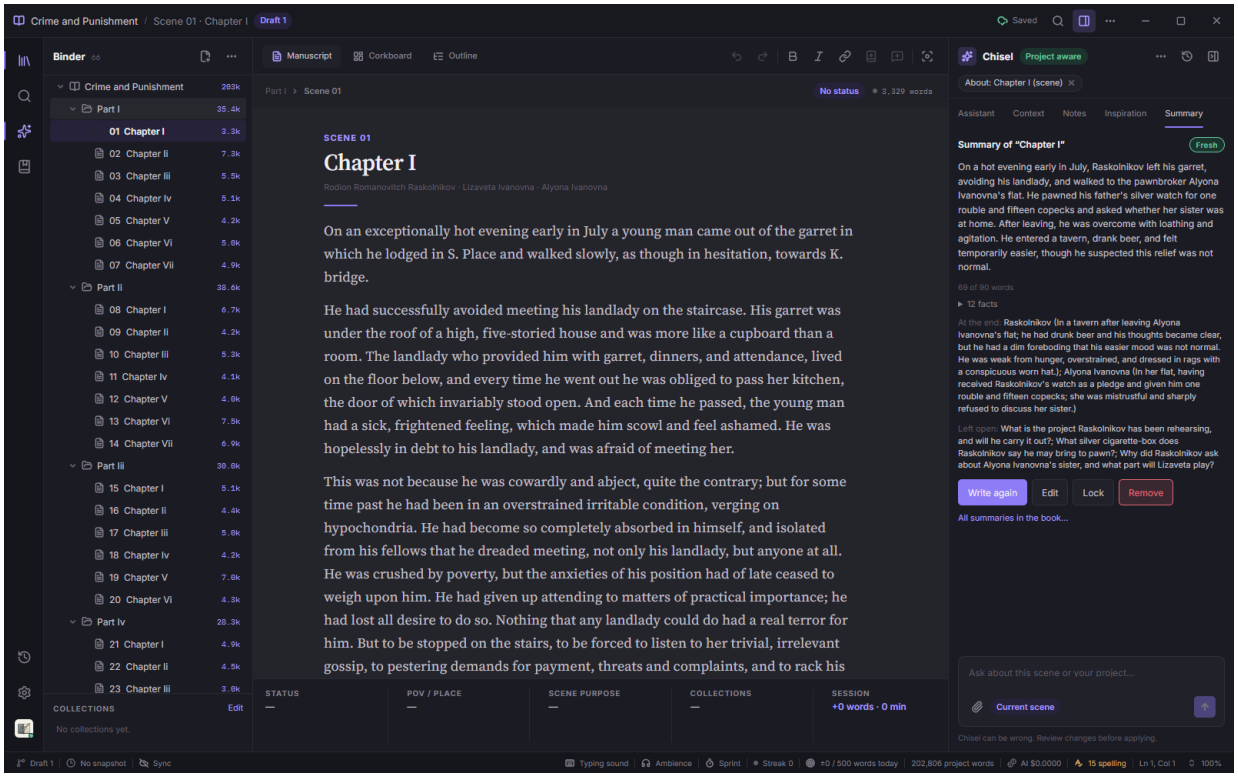


Figure 22. *The Summary card for the open chapter: status (Fresh), the summary, its twelve facts (quote on hover), where each character stands at the end, and the open questions. Buttons: Write again, Edit, Lock, Remove.*

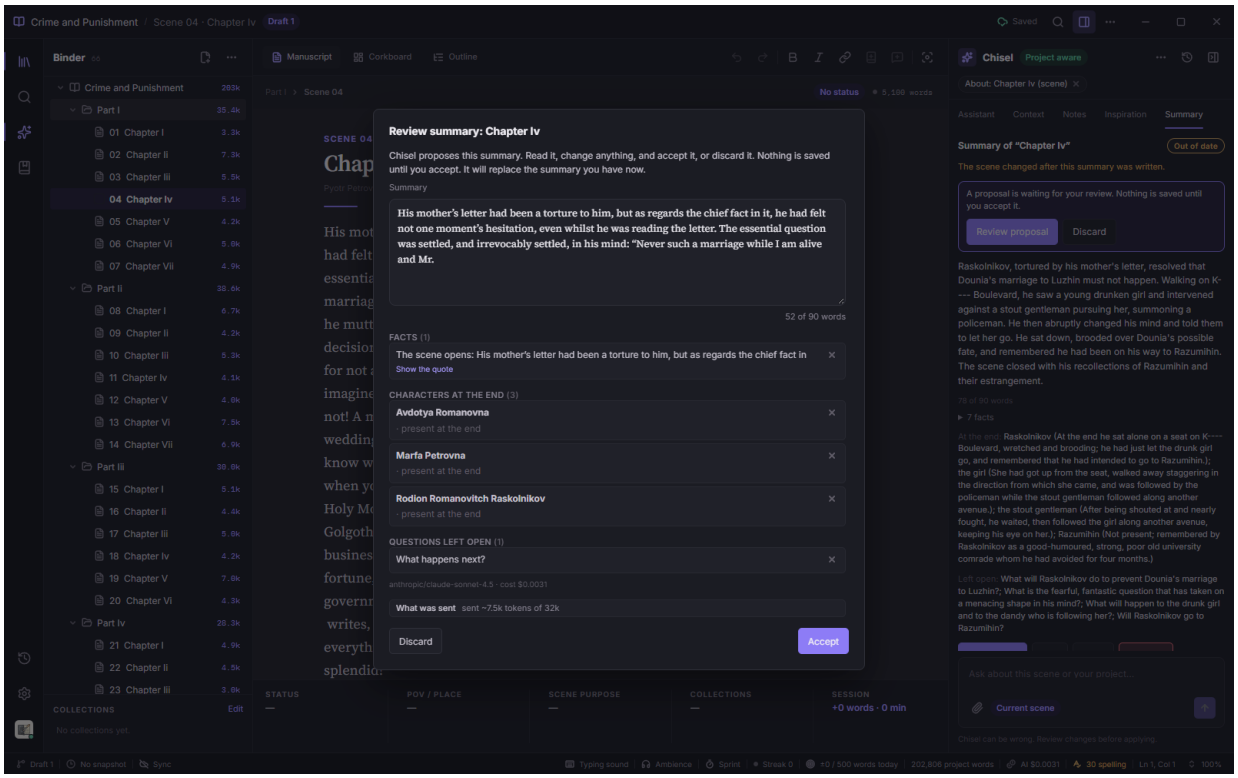


Figure 23. *The review dialog: edit the proposed summary, drop any fact, see what verification left out and what was sent. Nothing is saved until Accept.*

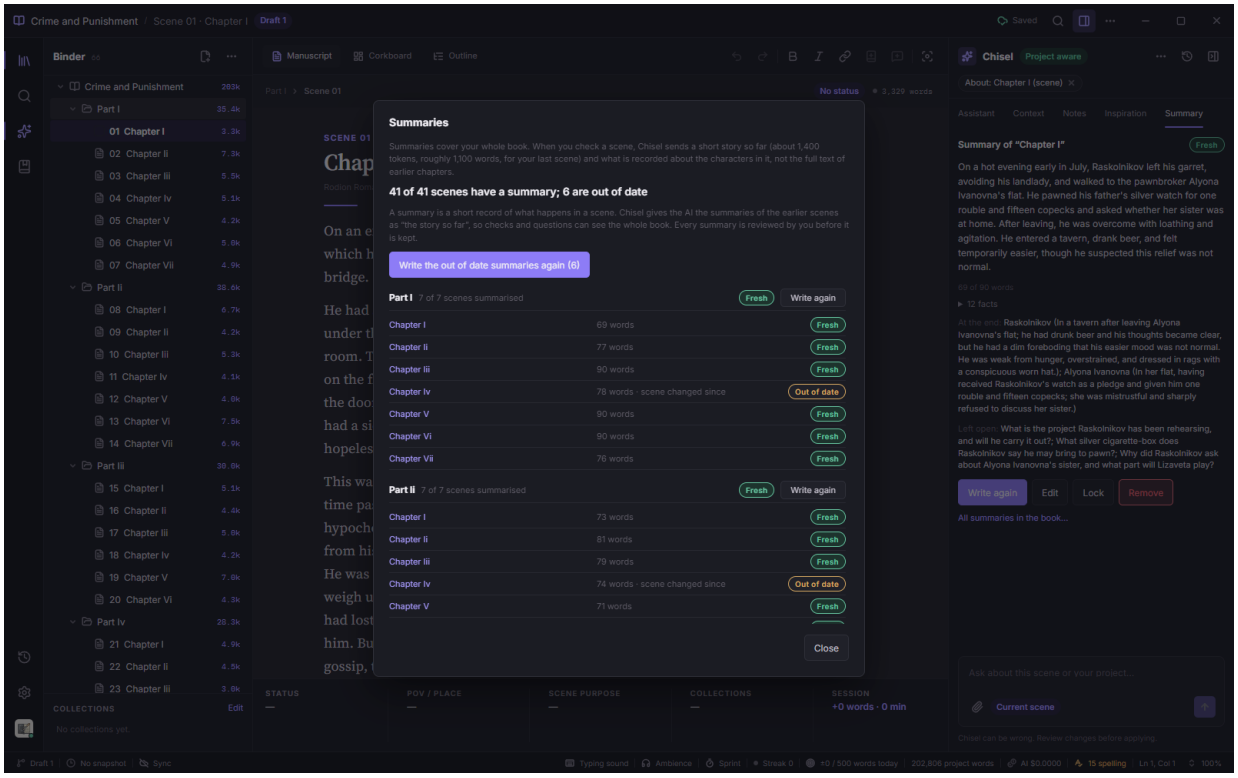


Figure 24. *The Summaries panel for the whole book: coverage, per-part and per-scene status, a button that shows the cost before writing missing summaries, and a muted line saying what the AI still does not see.*

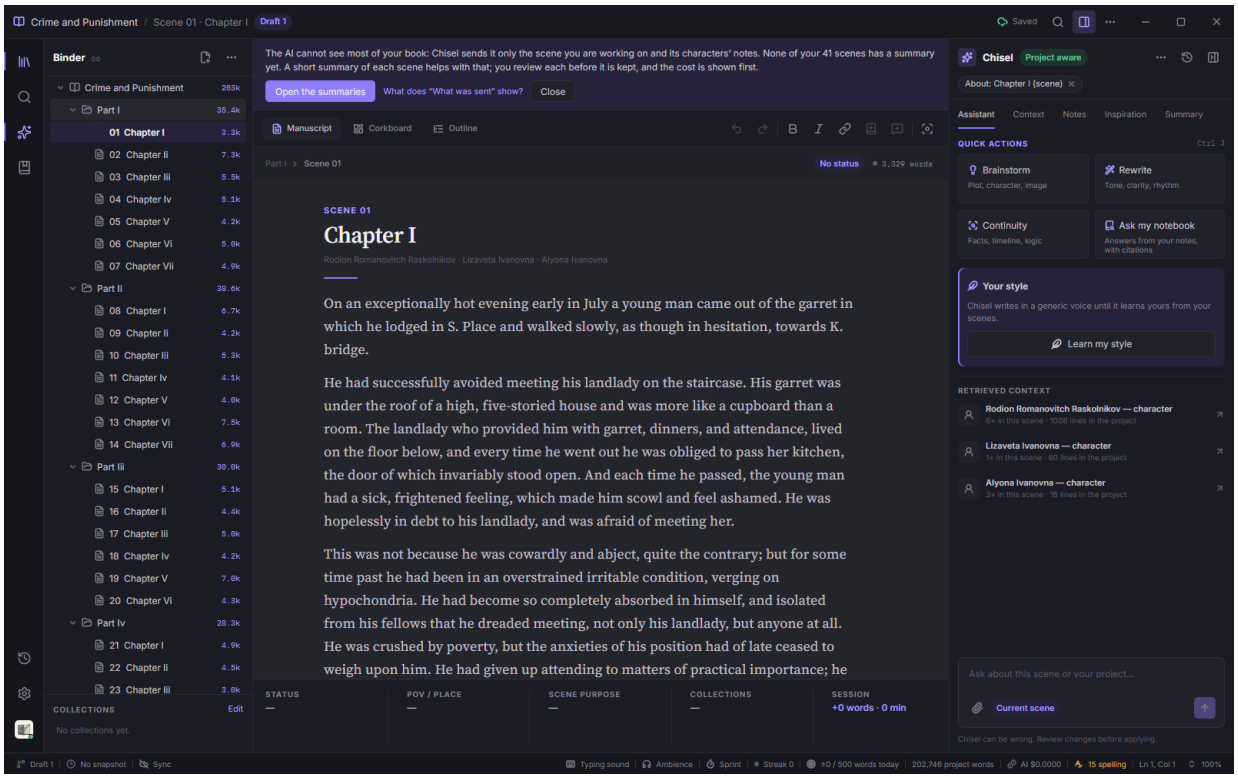


Figure 25. *The growth notice for a project with no summaries: two sentences, one action, dismissible, never blocks typing.*

The notice used to be a 110-word paragraph that said "only 0 of 41"; it is now about 55 words and says only what is true. I also changed "a summary fixes that" to "helps with that", because the experiments

do not justify "fixes". When every chapter has a summary the banner disappears, but the AI still sees only a few thousand tokens of the book, so the panel now says so in plain words. Screens for the terminal version of Chisel were not built.

9. What worked, what did not, what to do

Worked	Did not work, or not shown
Measuring what Chisel sends: a clear, repeatable picture with no AI cost	Summaries and the event-style fact list helping catch contradictions: at most 1 of 6 in four rounds
Summaries as a tool: cheap, fast, reviewed before saved, travel with the chapter, honest about being out of date	The cheap models as checkers: many false alarms, results flip run to run, GLM unusable in default mode
Quote-checked facts: 96% of offered facts kept after the fix, and a stress test found no false acceptance	Colours and family relations in summaries (0%): they belong in character notes
Turning thinking off for checking tools: 3.4x cheaper, 2x faster	The alias finder: returned nothing in every test; it does not learn nicknames at all
Notes2Flow caught a real flaw in our plan; AgenticNodes made the experiments repeatable and layered	Judging by a second AI: it said no to almost everything and never settled a case
Jev as a yes/no checker: 97% agreement on claims against book passages	The story-so-far at book scale: tiny next to the book; the beginning is dropped first
The free ceiling check told us why three paid rounds could not succeed; the canon-tool fix it pointed to raised the ceiling from 0 to 5 of 6 and catches from 0 to 2 or 3	False alarms: the notes-based check raises 5 to 8 of 8 untouched chapters; a wording fix made it worse; a code-checked two-quote rule cut them 40% but lost a catch; hand-written notes still catch more (4 against 2 to 3)

Table 7. *A plain scorecard.*

Limits of this study (please keep these in mind)
One book with full ground truth (the other two have names and sizes only); six planted edits and eight control chapters, so one catch more or less is within the noise; cheap models only (DeepSeek and GLM), several of them used with thinking off; most conditions run once or twice (round 5 twice, round 6 five); the model's behaviour drifted between sessions, so only runs interleaved within one session are comparable; the waiting findings were judged by me, an agent, not by you; the ceiling check uses a simple rule (the original value appears in a line naming the character). What the results do support: what Chisel sends today, that the summary tool works as a summary tool, that the first design could not have succeeded (the facts were not recorded), and that hand-written notes with a thinking model were the best of everything tried.

Recommendations, in order

- **Keep the summary feature as an overview memory** (story so far for chat, brainstorm and describe) and say what it is: a short record you review, not the AI having read your book. *Based on:* it is cheap (17 cents for War and Peace), reviewed, quote-checked and marks itself out of date (sections 4, 7, 8). This is option A.
- **Use the fixed canon tool as the continuity memory** (option B, built). It records stable details with one verified quote each; the author reviews what goes into the notes. *Based on:* the ceiling went from 0 to 5 of 6 and catches from 0 to 2 or 3 of 6 (round 5). *Still to do:* a one-click "build notes from my chapters" batch with review (today it is one chapter at a time), and tidy the 28% of facts the

model labels "other". Hand-written notes still catch more (four of six), so the author should be able to add to the notes by hand.

- **Decide on the two-quote check** (built, committed on its own branch, not merged). It cut false alarms by 40% and shows the author the notes line behind every finding, but one catch was lost in the five-run test (the margin missed the pre-set floor by 0.3). *Based on:* round 7. A cheap way to settle it is a larger repeat on more edits, or to adopt it as an option the author can switch on. A wording change alone did not work (round 6).
- **Fix existing weaknesses** (independent of options A and B): the 40-note cliff (order notes by relevance instead of cutting to the few named); the alias finder (let code locate the text, and consider a separate name-form discovery tool, since nothing finds nicknames today); names that wrap across a line. *Based on:* sections 3 and 4.
- **Ship the reasoning setting with a plain control.** Thinking off makes summaries 3.4 times cheaper and twice as fast, but continuity checking did better with thinking on (4 of 6 against 1 with the same hand-written notes): make the default depend on the task. *Based on:* section 4 table, section 5 round 1.
- **Do not claim book-scale continuity checking yet.** Re-test with a stronger model than these cheap ones, on a real manuscript, with at least five repetitions per condition. *Based on:* identical runs differed by about 30% and the limits box above.
- **Tooling follow-ups** (Appendix C): problems found in AgenticNodes and Notes2Flow along the way.

Your original question: do we need a summarisation tool?
A summary is the right shape for *what happened* and is worth having (overview, chat context, a map of the book). It is the wrong shape for *continuity*, which depends on small stable facts that a short summary leaves out: five of our six hidden contradictions concerned a fact that no summary recorded. Long-book consistency needs two layers: the story-so-far summaries for orientation, and a reviewed, quote-checked ledger of stable details per character, retrieved by who is in the scene. After the fix, the second layer can be produced automatically as a first draft for the author to review.

A last check: Notes2Flow on this report's own conclusions

To test the reasoning of this report, I wrote its conclusions as plain claims (with one decision and three options) and had Notes2Flow map them and run its logic review (Figure 26). All 60 quotes verified. It found real weaknesses, which I have corrected above: four key results (notes alone caught none; hand-written notes caught four of six; the quote-check stress test; the canon tool's three of six) were not tied to the recommendations they support; the chosen options were not linked to any action; and of nine "because" or "therefore" sentences only four were cleanly supported in the map (one match was accidental, four were missing or partial). The recommendations now cite their evidence and say which action carries out which option. Notes2Flow's own limits: one extraction, and it checks that a path exists, not that it is the right path.

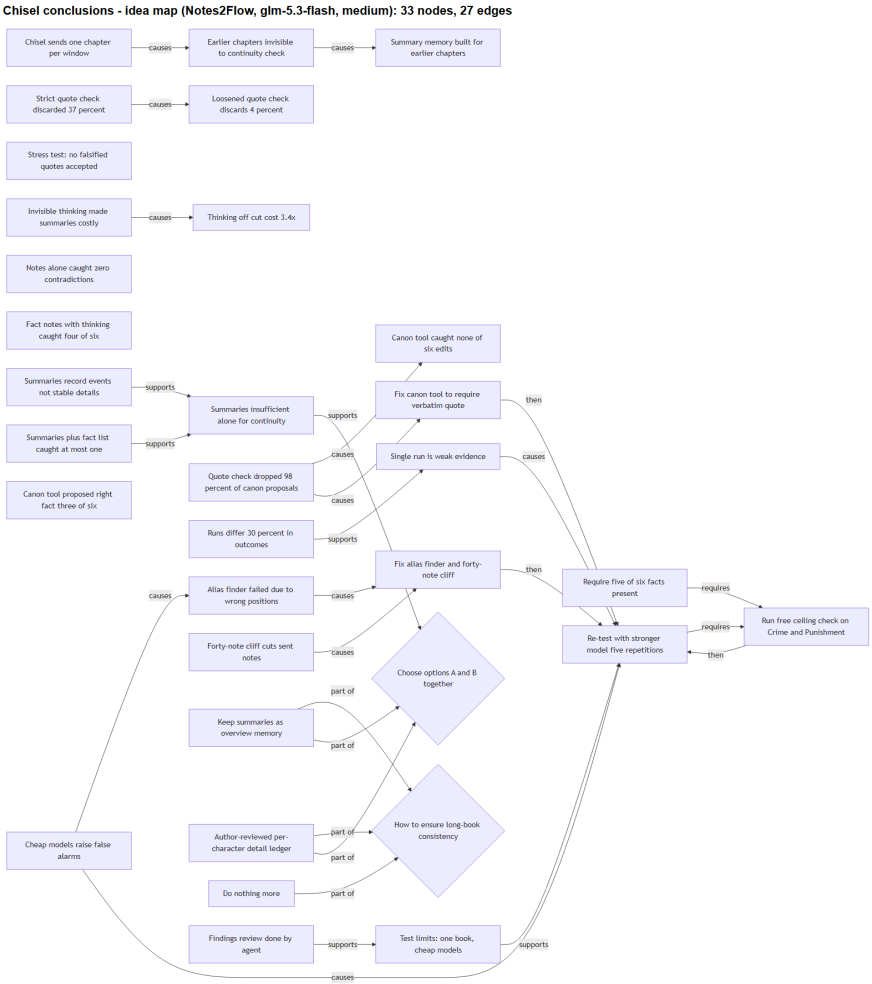


Figure 26. *Notes2Flow's map of this report's conclusions as written before round 5 (33 boxes; its statements about the canon tool are now superseded). The four unconnected results in the left column were the logic review's findings.*

Appendix A. Money and files

Phase	Calls logged	USD
Planning in Notes2Flow	4	0.0087
First real summaries, fidelity test, alias finder (gate 1)	11	0.1711
Diagnosis of the discarded facts	9	0.0151
Fixed summaries of Crime and Punishment (gate 2)	7	0.1147
Thinking off, alias finder, Jev check (gate 3)	11	0.0511
Continuity checks, round 1 (gate 4)	16	0.3647
Summaries of the two big books and the size test (gate 5)	64	0.2973
Continuity checks, round 2 (gate 6)	12	0.3990
Continuity checks, round 3 (gate 7)	3	0.1705
Canon tool as the source of details, round 4 (gate 8)	12	0.0900
Fixed canon tool, round 5 (gate 9)	12	0.0544
The check-prompt rule, round 6 (gates 10 to 12)	32	1.3840
The two-quote check, round 7 (gate 13)	12	0.2098
Total		**3.3304**

Table 8. *OpenRouter spend by phase (from SPEND.md; costs from the provider's responses).*

Everything is in `C:\Users\user\projects\chisel-longform-test`: `LOG.md` (decisions and reviews in order), `SPEND.md`, `plan/`, `briefs/` (what each helper was told), `work/workflow/GATE*_REPORT.md` (each experiment's own report), `work/builder/`, `reports/baseline/`, `data/truth/` (answer keys). The feature code is in the git worktree `C:\Users\user\projects\chisel-summaries-v2` (branch summaries-v2, nothing committed); the first version is frozen in `chisel-summaries` and dated copies `chisel-snap-v2a ... v2e`. The workflow is `AgenticNodes/agentic-nodes/examples/chisel_longform`. Local commits (nothing pushed anywhere): Chisel branch `summaries-v2` 77b7e9d (summaries, ledger, reasoning, screens), branch `canon-details` 92b1d42 (the canon fix); AgenticNodes `main` 5f2cda3, e5750cc 650fde0 and 2d111c7 (the chisel_longform example, the round 5 stages, the corrected slip list with the rescoring stage, and the round 7 harness). Chisel branch `two-quote` 1052ef2 (the two-quote check; built, not adopted).

Appendix B. A sheet for you to spot-check my calls

I answered the human-review queues (145 findings across the five rounds), as the manager agent, not as you. Please check these eleven; if you disagree with more than two, treat the false-alarm counts as unreliable.

#	What the AI said or what I judged	Where to look in the book	My call
1	Raskolnikov gives "twenty roubles, I think" but later Razumihin says he "flung away all the twenty-five at once"	Part II ch. VII ; Part III ch. V	Real slip in the book
2	"Amalia Ivanovna" versus "Amalia Fyodorovna" flagged as inconsistent	Part V ch. II (Katerina Ivanovna corrects the name)	Deliberate, false alarm
3	Svidrigaïlov offers ten thousand roubles (through Raskolnikov) but later says thirty thousand: flagged as a number clash	Part IV ch. I ; Part VI ch. IV (a second, separate offer: "all my money")	Two offers, false alarm
4	Svidrigaïlov "cannot have a betrothed while still married to Marfa Petrovna"	She has died by Part VI ch. IV	Model misreading, false alarm
5	Police office "third storey" contradicts the pawnbroker's building	Part VI ch. VIII (the police office)	False alarm
6	Raskolnikov's "black eyes" is a new attribute	Part I ch. I says dark eyes	False alarm
7	Raskolnikov denies seeing the painters though he did	Part III ch. V (he lies on purpose)	False alarm
8	Dounia holding the revolver contradicts earlier canon	Part VI ch. V (she took it from Svidrigaïlov's room)	False alarm
9	Part I ch. I summary: the pawnbroker lives on the fourth floor; the watch is silver; she gives one rouble fifteen copecks	Part I ch. I	Correct as far as I read
10	A fact kept by the looser quote rule: "Raskolnikov takes twenty-five roubles and copper change before leaving"; quote: "...looked at the money lying on the table, and after a moment's thought put it in his pocket. It was twenty-five roubles."	Part II ch. VI	Supported
11	Ilya Petrovitch says "you are rather early" at dusk; the model said the translator calls this an oversight	Part VI ch. VIII, with the translator's footnote	Real slip (ack nowledged in the footnote)
12	CORRECTION: "Luzhin's whiskers dark in Part II, flaxen in Part V" was listed as a real slip	Part V ch. I: the flaxen whiskers are Lebeziatnikov's (Andrey Semyonovitch)	Not a slip (my error)
13	CORRECTION: "Katerina's father an officer in Part I, a colonel in Part V" was listed as a real slip	Part V ch. II: she inflates his rank on purpose	Not a slip (my error)

Table 9. *Items to check against the book (Garnett translation).*

Appendix C. Problems found in the tools

- **AgenticNodes:** text and JSON inputs to external tools are pasted onto the command line (newlines refused, about 32,000-character limit, non-ASCII turned into question marks); a job's environment lacks HOME so some programs crash; `agn jobs logs` fails on non-ASCII; a tool with no listed files can serve a stale cache after the script changes; an identical second run is a replay unless the model node's cache is switched off; a run whose report stage changed after planning cannot resume. All listed in the workflow helper's report with suggested fixes.
- **Notes2Flow:** the first extraction silently dropped 17 relations (the raw model output is not kept so they cannot be recovered); one dependency was missing from the work-order flowchart; the logic review only checks for unconnected boxes, so it did not flag the missing step order.
- **herdr:** works well for starting and watching helpers. Folder-trust prompts need a person; a busy helper's status flickers to "done" while its background monitors still run, so I waited on output files instead.
- **Chisel:** see sections 3 to 5: the 40-note cliff, the 4,000-character pre-check, names across line breaks, the alias finder, empty replies from thinking models.

Appendix D. Words used

Word	Meaning here
Token	Chunk of text, about three-quarters of a word; the unit AI models read and bill in
Window	How many tokens a model can read at once
Thinking ("reasoning")	Hidden step-by-step work some models do before answering; billed, slow, invisible
Notes / canon	The text in a character's note that Chisel treats as established fact
Ledger	A short list of verified facts about the characters in the scene, built from the summaries
False alarm	The AI flags a problem in an untouched chapter that is not a real problem
Caught	The AI's finding identifies the planted contradiction (checked by rule, Jev or a person)
Jev	A specialised yes-or-no checking model by TypeSafe, reached through OpenRouter
Oracle notes (B)	Notes where every verified fact was written by hand: the best case for notes

Table 10. *Glossary.*